EPILOGUE

“Um shmum.”

David Ben-Gurion

Amona, a cluster of homes perched on a hilltop northeast of Ramallah, never officially existed. To the west was Ofra, one of the oldest settlements in the West Bank; on a hill to the east was Taybeh, a Christian village (and the home of Palestine’s only brewery). The residents lived in prefabricated trailers, lofted above the rocky terrain on cinder-blocks. They had a few gardens, and a small school at the edge of the hill, and chickens roaming the dirt paths between the caravans. The entire community contained about 300 people, roughly the population of my small street in Jaffa.

Yet for more than a month in late 2016, it was the dominant political issue in Israel. It consumed the government’s attention and enraged the Palestinians. There was even overblown talk that this cluster of trailers would bring down Netanyahu’s fourth government. It didn’t—but it did help to bring about a final diplomatic crisis between Israel and its closest allies, one unprecedented in its fury.

Amona is an “outpost”, a settlement built without official permission, and thus considered illegal even under Israeli law. But the government further differentiates between outposts built on privately-owned Palestinian land, and those built on “state land”, the large swathe of the West Bank designated as ownerless. The latter are often retroactively legalized. Rechelim, for example, was recognized as a legal settlement in 2012, more than two decades after the first residents pitched tents on a hilltop south of Nablus.

When the land is privately owned, however, the government’s hands are tied by a 1979 Supreme Court ruling, which held that the army could not seize Palestinian land to build civilian settlements. It has periodically been forced to demolish those outposts, like it did with Migron, outside of Ramallah, in 2012. (International law, of course, does not recognize any of